GARDEN CITY CHURCH

LIVE THE LIFE. TELL THE STORY.



BAPTISM

MATTHEW 3:13–17; 28:19 | MARK 16:16 | JOHN 3:5, 22–23 | ACTS 2:37–38; 16:30–33 | ROMANS 6:1–4 | EPHESIANS 4:4–6 | 1 PETER 3:18–22

WHAT IS BAPTISM?

Baptism is far more than a religious tradition—it's a powerful spiritual symbol rooted in Scripture. The word itself means "to immerse" or "to submerge," and it represents cleansing, death to the old self, and resurrection into new life. It is both deeply symbolic and spiritually significant.

From the Greek *baptizo* — "to immerse or submerge"

SYMBOLIZES

- **Cleansing** – Psalm 51:7; Ezekiel 36:25-27
- **Life and the Holy Spirit** – John 4:14; John 7:38–39
- **Death and resurrection** – Romans 6:4; Colossians 2:12

"Baptism is a public declaration of inward transformation"

WHY ARE WE BAPTIZED?

We are baptized because Jesus modeled it, commanded it, and because it reflects our obedience to Him. Baptism is not optional for the believer—it's a step of surrender and discipleship that testifies to Christ's work in us.

BIBLICAL SUPPORT

- Jesus was baptized – Matthew 3:15
- Jesus commanded baptism – Matthew 28:19
- The Early Church practiced it – Acts 2:38–41
- A picture of burial and resurrection – Romans 6:4
- New life in Christ – 2 Corinthians 5:17
- Obedience brings blessing – John 14:15

THE HISTORY OF BAPTISM

Baptism didn't start with Christianity—it has rich roots in Jewish tradition. From ceremonial washings to symbolic crossings like the Red Sea, water has always been part of God's redemptive narrative. The early Church embraced full immersion as the norm.

OLD TESTAMENT ROOTS

- Ceremonial washings – Numbers 8:7
- Cleansing – Psalm 51:7

BIBLICAL IMAGERY

- Noah's Ark – Genesis 6–8
- Red Sea crossing – Exodus 14

FIRST-CENTURY PRACTICE

- Full immersion in "living water"
- John the Baptist baptized for repentance – Matthew 3:5–6

ORDINANCES, NOT SACREMENTS

As Pentecostal believers, we embrace water baptism and communion as ordinances—not sacraments. These are commands we follow to express faith, not mystical acts that impart salvation. They are sacred, but they are not the source of salvation.

- **ASSEMBLIES OF GOD RECOGNIZES TWO ORDINANCES:**
  - Water Baptism
  - Holy Communion
- **ORDINANCES = ACTS OF OBEDIENCE, NOT CHANNELS OF GRACE**
- **ONLY CHRIST SAVES** – John 14:6; Ephesians 2:8–9

OBEDIENCE OVER MYSTICISM

Baptism is meaningful not because of magical waters, but because of obedience to God. Jesus submitted to baptism "to fulfill all righteousness," setting the example for us. There is power in obedience.

- Jesus' obedience – Matthew 3:15
- Baptism is not mystical but deeply meaningful
- Obedience activates spiritual growth – James 1:22

WHY WE DON'T BAPTIZE INFANTS

While some traditions baptize infants, we believe Scripture teaches that baptism follows personal faith and repentance. That's why we practice believer's baptism—a conscious, faith-filled choice. For infants, we practice dedication, as seen in the life of Jesus.

- Baptism requires belief – Acts 2:41; Acts 8:12
- Infants cannot repent or believe – Romans 10:9–10
- Dedication modeled by Jesus' parents – Luke 2:22–24
- Baptism follows spiritual rebirth, not physical birth – John 3:5

BAPTISM IS NOT SALVATION, IT'S A RESPONSE

You're not baptized to be saved—you're baptized because you are saved. Baptism is not what makes you a Christian, but it's what Christians do. Like a wedding ring, it's an outward sign of an inner covenant with Christ.

- Salvation by grace through faith – Ephesians 2:8–9
- Baptism is a response, not the cause of salvation – Mark 16:16
- Baptism follows salvation – Acts 8:36–38

BAPTIZED INTO CHRIST… AND OUT OF THE WORLD

In the early Church, baptism marked a radical turning point. To be baptized was to declare your separation from the world and allegiance to Christ. You weren't just entering the Church—you were exiting everything else.

- Early believers baptized immediately – Acts 16:30–33
- Baptism = declaration of new allegiance – Romans 6:1–4
- Entering Christ's Body – Ephesians 4:4–6

READY FOR THE JOURNEY

Baptism is the first step of many in your walk with Jesus. It's not for the perfect—it's for the repentant. If you're committed to follow Christ and have turned from your sin, you're ready to be baptized.

- Repentance comes first – Acts 2:38
- Following Jesus is a lifelong commitment – Luke 9:23

Baptism is the beginning, not the end.

HOW SHOULD WE BAPTIZE?

We baptize by immersion and in the Trinitarian name—Father, Son, and Holy Spirit—just as Jesus commanded. While some baptize "in Jesus' name" only, we follow the full biblical instruction.

- Baptism by immersion – Matthew 3:16
- Trinitarian formula – Matthew 28:19
- Full revelation of God (Father, Son, Spirit) – Matthew 3:16–17

CLOSING PRAYER OF COMMITMENT

Whether you're preparing to be baptized or reaffirming your walk with Christ, pray this from the heart:

"Jesus, I believe You are the Son of God. I repent of my sins and turn to You. I confess You as my Savior and Lord. Thank You for saving me. I commit to follow You with all my heart, from this day forward. Lead me, fill me, and help me live for You. In Jesus' name, Amen."